

Social Sciences as the Study of Society

Society permeates every dimension of human existence, yet the systematic study of society is a relatively recent intellectual endeavor. Natural scientists investigate the physical world through controlled experiments and empirical measurement. Humanists interpret texts, artworks, and cultural artifacts to explore questions of meaning and value. Social scientists, occupying a distinct intellectual terrain, examine human groups, institutions, behaviors, and relationships using systematic methods that blend empirical rigor with an acknowledgment of human complexity. Each approach offers a unique lens, yet none exists in isolation. Recognizing what distinguishes the social sciences from the natural sciences and the humanities – while also understanding how these branches of knowledge interconnect – constitutes the foundational step toward thinking critically about society.

This reading material differentiates the nature and functions of social science disciplines from the natural sciences and the humanities. It establishes the interconnections among social sciences, natural sciences, and the humanities. Finally, it defines social sciences as the study of society. By the end of this material, readers should be able to articulate not only what social scientists do but also how their work complements and depends upon insights from the natural sciences and the humanities.

Part 1: Social Sciences as the Study of Society

Many people assume that studying society is simply a matter of reading the news or forming opinions. Social science, however, is more rigorous than casual observation. It uses systematic methods, data collection, and theory-building to understand how people live together. The social sciences ask questions such as: Why do some societies experience poverty while others do not? How do cultures change over time? What makes governments stable or unstable? These questions cannot be answered by common sense alone. They require careful, methodical inquiry.

The **social sciences** are academic disciplines that study human society, social relationships, institutions, and behavior. Unlike casual observation, social science uses systematic methods to collect data, test theories, and draw conclusions about how people live together.

What Do Social Sciences Study?

Area of Study	What Social Scientists Ask
Society	How do groups form, function, and change?
Culture	What values, beliefs, and practices shape a community?
Power	Who gets what, when, and how?
Economy	How do people produce, distribute, and consume goods?
Behavior	Why do individuals and groups act the way they do?
History	How have past events shaped present conditions?

Examples of Social Science Disciplines

Discipline	Focus
Anthropology	Human origins, culture, and diversity
Economics	Production, distribution, and consumption of resources
Political Science	Power, governance, and political behavior
Sociology	Social structures, groups, and institutions
History	Past events and their causes and consequences

Discipline	Focus
Geography	Space, place, and the environment
Linguistics	Language and its social context
Psychology	Individual behavior and mental processes

Part 2: Differentiating Social Sciences from Natural Sciences and the Humanities

To understand the social sciences, one must see how they differ from two other major branches of knowledge: the natural sciences and the humanities. At first glance, all three seem to study different things – natural sciences study nature, social sciences study society, and humanities study culture. But the differences run deeper than subject matter alone. They differ in their goals, their methods, and their assumptions about what counts as knowledge. Natural scientists seek universal laws that can predict outcomes with certainty. Humanists seek interpretation and meaning, often embracing ambiguity. Social scientists fall somewhere in between. They seek patterns and explanations, but they acknowledge that human behavior is messy, unpredictable, and shaped by context. Recognizing these differences helps one appreciate what each branch of knowledge contributes uniquely.

The Three Branches of Knowledge

Branch	Subject Matter	Goal	Methods
Natural Sciences	The physical and natural world (atoms, cells, planets, chemicals)	To explain, predict, and control natural phenomena	Experimentation, observation, measurement, replication

Branch	Subject Matter	Goal	Methods
Social Sciences	Human society, relationships, institutions, and behavior	To understand, explain, and interpret social phenomena	Surveys, interviews, observation, statistical analysis, case studies
Humanities	Human culture, expression, and meaning (art, literature, philosophy, history)	To interpret, critique, and appreciate human experience	Critical analysis, interpretation, hermeneutics, textual analysis

Key Differences

Aspect	Natural Sciences	Social Sciences	Humanities
Subject	Objects, forces, organisms	People, groups, institutions	Texts, artworks, ideas
Objectivity	High (lab conditions, replication)	Moderate (humans are complex and unpredictable)	Low (interpretation varies)
Prediction	Often possible (e.g., eclipses, chemical reactions)	Limited (human behavior is not perfectly predictable)	Not applicable
Values	Strives to be value-free	Acknowledges values but aims for rigor	Embraces perspective and interpretation
Typical Question	What happens when water reaches 100°C?	Why do people vote the way they do?	What does this poem mean?

Examples Comparing the Same Topic

Topic	Natural Sciences Approach	Social Sciences Approach	Humanities Approach
Food	Chemistry of digestion; calorie measurement	Economic distribution of food; cultural eating habits	Food as metaphor in literature; philosophy of taste
Family	Genetics of inheritance	Sociology of marriage patterns; demography of fertility	Representations of family in art and film
City	Geography of landforms; physics of buildings	Urban sociology; political economy of city planning	City as symbol in poetry and photography

Part 3: Interconnections Among Social Sciences, Natural Sciences, and the Humanities

Despite their differences, these three branches of knowledge are deeply interconnected. Real-world problems rarely fit neatly into one category. A pandemic is a biological event (natural science), but it also disrupts economies (social science) and raises ethical questions about isolation and sacrifice (humanities). Climate change involves atmospheric chemistry (natural science), but it also requires policy responses (social science) and forces humans to ask what we owe to future generations (humanities). No single discipline can provide a complete answer to complex problems. Understanding how these branches interconnect – and how they depend on each other – is essential for anyone who wants to think critically about the world.

How They Overlap and Inform Each Other

Connection	Example
Natural sciences inform social sciences	Biology (genetics) informs psychology and anthropology. Climate science informs economic and political decisions about environmental policy.
Social sciences inform natural sciences	Sociology of science studies how scientific communities work. Economics influences which research gets funded.
Humanities inform social sciences	Philosophical ethics shapes social science research guidelines. Historical analysis provides context for sociological data.
Social sciences inform humanities	Psychological theories inform literary criticism. Anthropological concepts of culture inform art history.

Example: Studying Climate Change

Discipline	Contribution
Natural Sciences (climatology, biology)	Measures rising temperatures, models future scenarios, studies ecosystem impacts
Social Sciences (economics, political science, sociology)	Analyzes costs of mitigation, studies policy responses, examines social impacts on vulnerable communities
Humanities (philosophy, ethics, literature)	Asks moral questions about responsibility to future generations; represents human experience of loss and adaptation

Why These Interconnections Matter

Reason	Explanation
Complex problems	No single discipline can solve climate change, poverty, or pandemics alone
Richer understanding	Multiple perspectives reveal dimensions a single approach would miss
Better solutions	Policy decisions are stronger when informed by science, social science, and humanistic values

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Social sciences	Disciplines that study human society, relationships, institutions, and behavior using systematic methods
Natural sciences	Disciplines that study the physical and natural world through observation and experimentation
Humanities	Disciplines that study human culture, expression, and meaning through interpretation and critical analysis
Interconnection	The ways in which different disciplines overlap, inform, and depend on each other
Society	A group of people who share a common culture, territory, and institutions

Review Questions

1. Define social sciences in your own words. What do social scientists study?
2. Complete the following table comparing the three branches of knowledge:

Branch	Subject Matter	Goal	Typical Method
Natural Sciences			
Social Sciences			
Humanities			

3. Choose one real-world problem (e.g., poverty, climate change, public health, crime). Describe how natural sciences, social sciences, and humanities would each approach that problem differently.
4. Explain why the interconnections among natural sciences, social sciences, and humanities matter. Why is no single discipline sufficient to solve complex social problems?